

Dvar Torah Outline — The Fifth Cup, Hallel HaGadol, and the Order of the Seder (Maharal, Perek 65)

Abstract

Rabbi Shulman analyzes the Maharal's approach to the “fifth cup” at the Seder, framing it as a *reshut* precisely because it represents a higher, more subtle category of Hashem's kindness—especially *parnasah*—beyond the baseline gratitude owed for *geulah*. He then tackles a practical-nusach problem: if *Hallel HaGadol* belongs to the fifth cup (*parnasah*), why do many Hagados place it on the fourth cup, even interrupting between Hallel and its concluding *berachah* (*Birkat HaShir*)? Rabbi Shulman clarifies the Maharal's preferred structure: keep the formal Hallel framework intact, and place additional praises (like *Nishmat* and *Hallel HaGadol*) only afterward—either with a fifth cup or without.

I. The fundamental distinction: four cups (obligation) vs. fifth cup (optional)

A. The Maharal's “counterintuitive” yesod

- Rabbi Shulman explains that the **first four cups are a חובה**, while the **fifth cup is a רשות**.
- The surprising point: the fifth cup is *optional* **because it reflects a higher מדרגה** of 'חסדי ה'.

B. Why higher can be less obligatory

- The four cups focus on **ישועה / גאולה**: being saved from suffering and oppression.
 - This is “baseline gratitude”—so obvious that one “would have to be blind” to miss it.
- The fifth cup is about broader **חסדים**—more **כללי** and more nuanced.
 - Because it's subtler and not “in your face,” it is not legislated as an unavoidable **חיוב**.

C. Two analogies Rabbi Shulman uses

- **Birkat HaMazon**
 - First three berachot are **דאורייתא** (food, Eretz Yisrael, and its spiritual significance).
 - **מדרבנן** is **הטוב והמטיב**: a higher-level recognition of Hashem's ongoing kindness.
- **Kiddush**
 - **Kiddush Friday night: דאורייתא**—can't miss the point of Shabbat.

- Kiddush daytime (קידושא רבא): מדרבנן—more nuanced; without Chazal one might miss it.
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II. The Maharal's core question: why put Hallel HaGadol on the fourth cup? (3:32)

A. The placement problem

- Rabbi Shulman quotes the Maharal's challenge: if *Hallel HaGadol* is the “extra” praise associated with the fifth cup, why is it commonly said on **cup four**?
- Worse: it creates an interruption:
 - It **separates** between **Hallel** and **Nishmat / Birkat HaShir**, which should function as the conclusion of Hallel.

B. The Maharal's sharp claim

- Rabbi Shulman highlights the Maharal's language: “אין טעם לדבר הזה כלל”—there is no reason for inserting it there.
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III. Why the fifth cup is tied to parnasah (and therefore to Hallel HaGadol) (5:00)

A. The fifth cup's “ikkar takanah”

- Rabbi Shulman explains the Maharal's assertion:
 - **כוס חמישי** was primarily established for **פרנסה / מזונות**,
 - which is described as an even “greater” manifestation than geulah.

B. Proof from the alternative opinion: saying Tehillim 23

- Rabbi Shulman cites the Maharal's proof: some say to recite “ה' רועי לא אחסר” on the fifth cup.
 - This is clearly about sustenance and being provided for—confirming the fifth cup's parnasah theme.

C. Why Hallel HaGadol fits parnasah specifically

- The centerpiece phrase of Hallel HaGadol is:
 - “נותן לחם לכל בשר כי לעולם חסדו” (“Who gives bread to all flesh, for His kindness is eternal.”)

- Therefore, Rabbi Shulman explains, it does **not** belong inside the Hallel of geulah (cup four).
 - Either:
 1. Say Hallel HaGadol **with a fifth cup**, or
 2. Don't say it at all—but **don't wedge it into cup four**.
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IV. Textual/halachic support: where is Hallel HaGadol on cup four found? (8:30)

A. Rabbi Shulman explains the Maharal's "where is this in Shas?"

- The Maharal asks: where do we ever see in the Talmud a requirement to say Hallel HaGadol on **cup four**?
- **Mishnah**: discusses **four cups** without mentioning Hallel HaGadol.
- **Beraita (Rabbi Tarfon's view)**: mentions Hallel HaGadol in the context of the **fifth cup**.

B. The Rashbam's girsa vs. standard texts

- Rabbi Shulman notes: only the **Rashbam's girsa** supports placing Hallel HaGadol on cup four.
- But the Maharal rejects that as not matching the accepted textual tradition.

C. A consistency argument from "ה' רועי לא אחסר"

- If one would never insert "ה' רועי לא אחסר" into the fourth cup's Hallel,
 - then one likewise shouldn't insert **Hallel HaGadol** there, since both are "parnasah-themed."
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V. Birkat HaShir: what concludes Hallel on the fourth cup? (11:30)

A. The earlier sugya Rabbi Shulman revisits

- There is a machloket what **Birkat HaShir** is:
 - **Nishmat**, or
 - **יהללך** (and the surrounding praise structure).

B. The Rif and Rambam's implications

- Rabbi Shulman explains that the Maharal reads the **Rif** as supporting:
 - fourth cup: Hallel ending properly with its conclusion,

- fifth cup (optional): Hallel HaGadol,
- and if no fifth cup: no obligation to say Hallel HaGadol.

C. The Maharal's bottom-line concern

- Do not “uproot” the structured order of Chazal by:
 1. doing both sides of a machloket as though both are required, and
 2. inserting Hallel HaGadol in the middle of the Hallel/Birkat HaShir unit.
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VI. What the “correct minhag” should look like (Maharal's proposed structure) (15:01)

A. Keep the essential Hallel framework intact

- Rabbi Shulman explains the Maharal's recommended sequence:
 1. **Say Hallel** and finish it with the proper concluding berachah (the core halachic closure),
 2. **Then** add additional praises afterward (like Nishmat),
 3. **Then** say Hallel HaGadol—so it doesn't interrupt the Hallel unit.

B. Rabbi Shulman's clarification of the Maharal's intent (resolving apparent switches)

- Rabbi Shulman notices the text seems to shift between ending with Nishmat vs. ending with יהללוך.
- He proposes the cleanest reading:
 - **End Hallel with יהללוך** as the formal Birkat HaShir (following the Rif's “ikkar hadin”),
 - **Afterward**, add **Nishmat** “because you want to be extra,”
 - **Afterward**, add **Hallel HaGadol** (as an extra unit, not embedded inside Hallel).

C. The Maharal's critique of “doing everything”

- Rabbi Shulman paraphrases the Maharal's frustration:
 - It's a machloket Amoraim (Nishmat vs. יהללוך),
 - yet the common practice looks like: do **both**, and also insert Hallel HaGadol **between** them.
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VII. If you do use a fifth cup: what berachah belongs with it? (24:31)

A. The question

- Rabbi Shulman explains the Maharal's kasheh:
 - Cups 1–4 each accompany a significant berachah-unit (Kiddush, Maggid, Birkat HaMazon, Birkat HaShir).
 - If the fifth cup is for Hallel HaGadol, what “closing” berachah accompanies it?

B. The Maharal's answer

- Since the fifth cup is **not fixed** (רשות), **no special berachah** was established for it.
 - Practically: it would be Hallel HaGadol as praise, and **בורא פרי הגפן** on the cup—without a unique additional berachah-unit.
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VIII. If you do *not* make a fifth cup: can you still say Hallel HaGadol? (27:00)

A. Rabbi Shulman notes the text's implication

- Even without a fifth cup, it is acceptable to say Hallel HaGadol—just not as an interruption inside the fourth-cup Hallel structure.

B. Practical takeaway framed by the Maharal

- If skipping the fifth cup, then:
 - complete cup four's Hallel properly (with its closure),
 - then add Nishmat and Hallel HaGadol afterward as “extras,” without disrupting the halachic sequence.
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In Summary

- Rabbi Shulman explains the Maharal's יסוד: the **fifth cup is optional** not because it's lesser, but because it reflects a **higher, subtler** recognition of Hashem's kindness—especially **parnasah**.
- **Hallel HaGadol** belongs with the fifth cup's theme (not geulah), centered on **נותן לחם לכל בשר כי לעולם חסדו**.

- Placing Hallel HaGadol on **cup four** is problematic because it **interrupts** the Hallel → Birkat HaShir structure.
- The Maharal's preferred סדר: **finish Hallel properly first**, and only then add **Nishmat** and **Hallel HaGadol**—either with a fifth cup or without one, but not embedded in the middle.